

LESSON GUIDE

Color Fundamentals

Color is the most emotionally immediate element of visual design. Before exploring advanced color theory, this lesson builds a working vocabulary: hue, saturation, value, temperature, and the harmony systems that make color combinations feel intentional rather than accidental.

4-WEEK PLAN

Week 1 — Color Properties

Mix colors from primaries and identify hue, saturation, and value independently. Practice desaturating a color without changing its hue by adding its complement.

Week 2 — Color Temperature

Paint or draw the same object twice: once under warm light (golden hour), once under cool light (overcast). Note how the shadow color shifts with the light source.

Week 3 — Color Harmony

Create three compositions using different harmony types: complementary (opposite colors), analogous (adjacent colors), and triadic (three colors equidistant on the wheel).

Week 4 — Limited Palette

Complete a color study using only three primaries and white. Discover the mixing range and limitations. Note which mixes become muddy and why.

KEY CONCEPTS

Hue, Saturation & Value

The three properties of every color. Hue is the color name. Saturation is its purity. Value is its lightness or darkness. All three must be considered together.

Color Temperature

Warm colors (reds, oranges, yellows) advance visually and feel energetic. Cool colors (blues, greens, purples) recede and feel calm. Temperature is relative — always compare.

Local Color vs. Light Color

Local color is the true color of a surface under neutral light. Light color modifies local color according to the light source's color temperature.

Color Mixing

How colors interact when mixed. In pigment, mixing is subtractive — more pigments absorb more light. In light, mixing is additive — combining primaries creates white.

Complementary Colors

Colors opposite on the color wheel. Complementaries create maximum contrast, vibrate visually when placed side by side, and neutralize each other when mixed.

Color Harmony

Systematic relationships between colors that create pleasing combinations: complementary, split-complementary, analogous, triadic, tetradic.

ESSENTIAL RESOURCES

- James Gurney — Color and Light (essential book for serious artists)
- Blender Guru — Understanding Color (one of the best free color tutorials)
- Adobe Color — color.adobe.com (free interactive color harmony tool)
- Proko — Color theory fundamentals for artists (YouTube)
- Tyler Edlin Art — Color temperature deep dive (YouTube)